



SHAIKSHI HAZA

to act. "We have information but it is not proper for me to disclose that information at this point of time or blame any organisation because it has implications." It is Shivraj Patil post-Ahmedabad, and it is as enlightening as what he had said about the threat to national security in a television interview immediately after taking over: "The disease within the body is more dangerous"—whatever it means. Effete and evasive, he is the home minister in a Government that can do nothing but cry "FBI" in utter exasperation whenever it is under attack. We don't expect from this Government a department of homeland security or an Indian version of America's Patriot Act or extraordinary rendition or, for that matter, a Gitmo in the Andamans for the higher cause of national security. What about an alternative to the "draconian" Prevention of Terrorism Act (POTA)? State governments like Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan are not even given the permission to pass their own anti-terrorism laws while Uttar Pradesh and Gujarat are awaiting pres-

idential assent to their bills against terror. A government that allows a terrorist condemned to the gallows to become a living symbol for the perennially disenchanted but the vote-rich minorities is unlikely to identify radical Islamism as a threat to India. So it will go on triangulate in politically correct malarkey, with the home minister as its bumbling interlocutor.

And India will continue to be savaged. Today, in the post-9/11 statistics of terror, India, a liberal democracy, is second only to post-Saddam Iraq, liberated but at war with itself. This terrifying truth magnifies the failure of the state—and the entire political class which is never united by grief or fear. Sadly, even when the new generation faces of Kashmir—one of the oldest datelines of Islamic terror—went eloquent about 'Being Indian' in Parliament, the war against India in the Valley found no place in their nationalist script. As long as India refuses to shed its shameful political expediency, we can only wallow in our victimhood. We deserve better. ■

**TERROR
ZONE:
Ahmedabad
was rocked by
17 explosions**